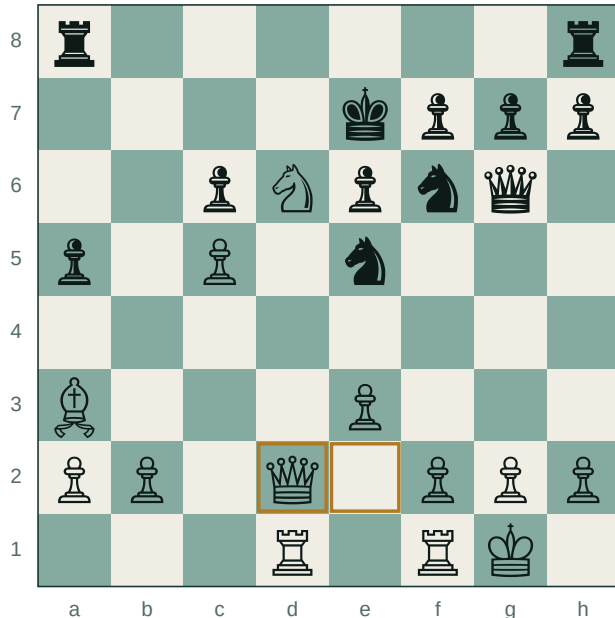


Pins and pressure: Black, move 20

Pins and pressure

Black to move



Previous move: 20.Qd2. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

20...Nf3+ 21. Kh1 Nxd2

20...Nf3+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. From f3 it attacks king on g1 and queen on d2. Recorded reply: **21.Kh1**.

21...Nxd2 The knight captures the queen on d2.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 31 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +9. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +9: the balance goes from -1 to +8. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A pinned piece can sometimes move along the line, capture the pinning piece, or answer with a forcing resource.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A pin limits a piece because moving it exposes a more important target. A pin to the king restricts legality; a pin to another piece changes the practical cost of moving.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace the line through attacker, pinned piece, and rear target. Test whether the pinned piece is being counted as a defender it cannot really be.

The defending king is on g1. Absolute pin: pawn on g2.